2.1 The Louisiana Purchase

We all know our nation spans the continent from "sea to shining sea," but in the early 1800s, the western border of the United States was the Mississippi River. Thomas Jefferson took steps to change that.

MAIN IDEA Thomas Jefferson negotiated a deal with France to purchase the Louisiana Territory and doubled the size of the United States.

PORT OF NEW ORLEANS

While the Supreme Court dealt with the midnight judges, Jefferson set his sights on expansion. The population in the region between the Appalachian Mountains and the Mississippi River had grown steadily. Now farmers were settling the area and shipping their crops down the tributaries of the Mississippi to New Orleans. From there, ships carried cargo to ports all over the world. Jefferson wanted to acquire New Orleans. Only France stood in his way.



In 1799, **Napoleon Bonaparte** overthrew the revolutionary government in France and took power. In 1800, he signed a secret treaty requiring Spain to return Louisiana to France. The Spanish government had decided that, with only 50,000 settlers in all of Louisiana, the area was too expensive to maintain and produced too little profit. But Jefferson feared that once France owned Louisiana, it would interfere with American shipping in New Orleans. Fortunately for Jefferson, France now felt as burdened with Louisiana as Spain had and was very willing to sell the territory to another nation. Soon, peaceful negotiations began between Napoleon and the United States.

NAPOLEON'S OFFER

Jefferson began by sending James Monroe to France in 1803 to help negotiate the purchase of territory at the mouth of the Mississippi, including New Orleans. However, negotiations began to stall on the French side. Napoleon was having trouble in another part of the Americas—the Caribbean colony of Saint-Domingue, now known as Haiti, on the island of Hispaniola. In 1791, **Toussaint L'Ouverture** (TOO-sahnt LOH-ver-toor) had led a successful revolution to free slaves in the French colony. L'Ouverture governed the island until 1802, when Napoleon decided he wanted the colony back. But his actions resulted in an all-out war.

Napoleon had had enough of the Americas. His forces had been reduced by **yellow fever**, an often-fatal disease carried by mosquitoes in tropical climates, and he surrendered to Haitian independence. Without Saint-Domingue, Napoleon felt that Louisiana had little value. As a result, the

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AMERICAN PLACES

The Cabildo, New Orleans, Louisiana

Now a Louisiana State Museum, the Cabildo was the site of the Louisiana Purchase transfer ceremonies in 1803. The Cabildo, which means "city council" in Spanish, originally housed Spain's government in New Orleans.



French leader decided to give up all his territory in continental North America. Instead of selling only New Orleans to the United States, Napoleon suggested selling the entire Louisiana Territory—all 828,000 square miles of it—for $15 million. In October 1803, the U.S. Senate ratified the treaty that established the **Louisiana Purchase**. France officially transferred the land to the United States, doubling the size of the nation.

Jefferson had some misgivings about the deal. He debated the constitutionality of the purchase, saying, "The General Government has no powers but such as the Constitution gives it. . . . It has not given it power of holding foreign territory, and still less of incorporating it into the Union. An amendment of the Constitution seems necessary for this." But Jefferson ended up putting his concerns aside. The land, he believed, would provide space for generations of American farmers and allow people in the region to trade freely on the Mississippi. Soon after the treaty with France was finalized, Jefferson funded an expedition to take a good look at the land and natural resources the country had bought. He could hardly wait to hear what the explorers learned about the plants, animals, and people in the region.

HISTORICAL THINKING

1. **READING CHECK** Why did Jefferson want to purchase Louisiana from France?
2. **ANALYZE CAUSE AND EFFECT** What happened as a result of war in Saint-Domingue?
3. **INTERPRET MAPS** What major river did the United States acquire the rights to in the Louisiana Purchase?

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